长城：传说与事实

一道墙，还是很多道墙?

The Great Wall: Myth and Fact

One wall, or many?

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 长城[1]是中国最有名的建筑之一，也是世界上最有名的古代建筑之一。中国人常常叫它“万里长城[2]”，意思是它非常非常长。关于长城，人们有很多说法[3]，有的是真的，有的只是传说。比如，很多人以为长城是一道很长的墙、是一个皇帝[4]在很短的时间里修好的；还有人说，从太空[5]中用眼睛就能看到长城。这些说法对不对呢？下面我们一起来看一看。

不是一道墙，而是很多道墙

2 其实，长城不是一道墙，而是很多道墙。它们是在两千多年里，由不同的国家和朝代[6]修建[7]的。早在两千多年前的战国[8]时期[9]，中国还没有统一，北方和中原[10]有很多国家。

1 建筑 *jiànzhù* building, structure
2 万里长城 *Wànlǐ Chángchéng* the “Ten-Thousand-Li Great Wall”
3 说法 *shuōfǎ* claim, version
4 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
5 太空 *tàikōng* outer space
6 朝代 *cháodài* dynasty
7 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
8 战国 *Zhànguó* the Warring States (475–221 BC)
9 时期 *shíqī* period
10 中原 *Zhōngyuán* the Central Plains

The Great Wall is one of the most famous buildings in China, and one of the most famous ancient structures in the world. Chinese people often call it the "Ten-Thousand-Li Great Wall", meaning that it is very, very long. People say many things about the Great Wall: some of them are true, and some are only legends. For example, many people think the Great Wall is one long wall that a single emperor built in a short time; others say that you can see it with the naked eye from space. Are these claims right? Let us take a look together. 1

Not One Wall, but Many

In fact, the Great Wall is not one wall but many walls. They were built over more than two thousand years by different states and dynasties. As early as the Warring States period, more than two thousand years ago, China was not yet unified, and there were many states in the north and on the Central Plains. 2

2 这些国家之间常常打仗[1]，北边还有经常南下的游牧[2]民族。为了保护自己，很多国家都在边界[3]上修了长长的墙，这就是最早的长城。

3 公元前二百二十一年，秦始皇[4]统一了中国。他让大将蒙恬[5]带着几十万人，把原来秦[6]、赵[7]、燕[8]三个国家在北方修的长城连接[9]起来，又修了很多新的部分。这样，北方第一次有了一道连在一起的长城，用来[10]防止匈奴[11]人的进攻[12]。秦朝[13]的长城大部分是用土修的，今天能看到的已经不多了。

4 汉朝[14]的时候，长城又变得更长了。为了保护通往[15]西方的丝绸之路[16]，汉朝把长城一直修到了西边的沙漠[17]里。

1 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to fight a war
2 游牧 *yóumù* nomadic
3 边界 *biānjiè* border
4 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor
5 蒙恬 *Méng Tián* Meng Tian, a Qin general
6 秦 *Qín* the State of Qin
7 赵 *Zhào* the State of Zhao
8 燕 *Yān* the State of Yan
9 连接 *liánjiē* to link, to join
10 用来 *yònglái* to be used for
11 匈奴 *Xiōngnú* the Xiongnu, northern nomads
12 进攻 *jìngōng* attack
13 秦朝 *Qíncháo* the Qin dynasty
14 汉朝 *Hàncháo* the Han dynasty
15 通往 *tōngwǎng* leading to
16 丝绸之路 *Sīchóu zhī Lù* the Silk Road
17 沙漠 *shāmò* desert

These states often fought one another, and further north lived nomadic peoples who frequently rode south. To protect themselves, many states built long walls along their borders. These were the earliest Great Walls. 2

In 221 BC, Qin Shi Huang unified China. He sent his general Meng Tian with several hundred thousand men to join up the walls that the states of Qin, Zhao and Yan had built in the north, and to build many new sections as well. In this way the north had, for the first time, a single connected wall, which was used to keep out attacks by the Xiongnu. Most of the Qin wall was made of earth, and not much of it can still be seen today. 3

In the Han dynasty, the wall grew longer still. To protect the Silk Road leading to the west, the Han carried the wall all the way into the western deserts. 4

4 在今天甘肃[1]的敦煌[2]附近，人们还能看到两千年前的汉[3]长城和烽火台[4]。后来的很多朝代[5]也修过长城，有的修得多，有的修得少。

5 我们今天看到的长城，特别是北京附近那些用砖[6]修的、又高又大的长城，大部分是明朝[7]修的。明朝从1368年到1644年，一共两百多年。这段时间里，明朝几乎一直在修长城。人们常说，明[8]长城“东起山海关[9]，西到嘉峪关[10]”，其实它的东边一直到了辽宁[11]。根据2009年的测量，明长城一共有八千八百多公里。如果把历史上所有朝代修的长城加在一起，总长度[12]有两万多公里。所以，“万里”一点也不夸张[13]。古代的一万里[14]大约是五千公里，而长城的总长度是它的四倍还多。

1 甘肃 *Gānsù* Gansu Province
2 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang, an oasis city in Gansu
3 汉 *Hàn* Han (dynasty)
4 烽火台 *fēnghuǒtái* beacon tower
5 朝代 *cháodài* dynasty
6 砖 *zhuān* brick
7 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty
8 明 *Míng* Ming (dynasty)
9 山海关 *Shānhǎiguān* Shanhaiguan Pass
10 嘉峪关 *Jiāyùguān* Jiayuguan Pass
11 辽宁 *Liáoníng* Liaoning Province
12 长度 *chángdù* length
13 夸张 *kuāzhāng* exaggerated
14 一万里 *yīwànlǐ* ten thousand li

Near Dunhuang in today's Gansu, you can still see Han walls and beacon towers from two thousand years ago. Many later dynasties built walls too, some a great deal, some only a little. 4

The Great Wall we see today, especially the tall, massive brick sections near Beijing, was mostly built by the Ming dynasty. The Ming dynasty lasted from 1368 to 1644, more than two hundred years in all. Throughout this time, the Ming were building wall almost without a break. It is often said that the Ming wall "begins at Shanhaiguan in the east and ends at Jiayuguan in the west", but in fact its eastern end reaches as far as Liaoning. According to a survey in 2009, the Ming wall is a little over 8,800 kilometres long in total. If you add together the walls built by every dynasty in history, the total length is more than twenty thousand kilometres. So "ten thousand li" is no exaggeration at all. Ten thousand li in the old measure is about five thousand kilometres, and the total length of the walls is more than four times that. 5

长城是怎么修的

6 修长城的时候，人们一般用的是当地能找到的材料。在北方的平原[1]上，最常见的方法是夯土[2]：先用木板[3]做成一个框子[4]，再把土倒进去，然后用工具一层一层地打结实。这样修出来的土墙非常结实，有的已经站了两千多年。在西边的沙漠[5]里，土很少，人们就把沙子、小石头和芦苇[6]一层一层地放在一起。

7 到了明朝[7]，修长城的技术有了很大的进步。在山上，人们用大石头修墙的下面，上面再用砖[8]。这些砖是在附近专门烧的，有的砖上还写着做砖的时间和地方。据说，有的地方在石灰[9]里加了糯米[10]汤，这样砖和砖之间就粘[11]得更牢[12]。科学家研究以后发现，这种“糯米灰浆[13]”真的非常结实。

1 平原 *píngyuán* plain
2 夯土 *hāngtǔ* rammed earth
3 木板 *mùbǎn* wooden board
4 框子 *kuàngzi* frame
5 沙漠 *shāmò* desert
6 芦苇 *lúwěi* reeds
7 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty
8 砖 *zhuān* brick
9 石灰 *shíhuī* lime
10 糯米 *nuòmǐ* glutinous rice
11 粘 *zhān* to stick
12 牢 *láo* firm, fast
13 糯米灰浆 *nuòmǐ huījiāng* sticky-rice lime mortar

How the Wall Was Built

When building the wall, people generally used whatever materials they could find locally. On the northern plains, the most common method was rammed earth: first a frame was made from wooden boards, then earth was poured in and pounded firm with tools, layer by layer. Earth walls made this way are extremely solid; some have been standing for more than two thousand years. In the western deserts, where there was little earth, people laid sand, small stones and reeds together in alternating layers. 6

By the Ming dynasty, wall-building techniques had made great progress. In the mountains, builders used large stones for the lower part of the wall and bricks above. The bricks were fired specially nearby, and some of them still bear the date and place they were made. It is said that in some places rice soup made from glutinous rice was added to the lime, so that the bricks stuck together more firmly. Scientists who studied this “sticky rice mortar” found that it really is very strong. 7

8 修长城是一件非常辛苦[1]的工作。很多长城修在山上，路很难走，很重的石头和成千上万[2]块砖[3]都要靠人和动物运[4]上去。据说，有的地方的人排成长队，一块一块地把砖传上山；还有人让山羊背着砖往上爬。修长城的人有士兵，也有农民和犯人[5]，很多人再也没有回到家乡。

9 长城也不只是一道墙。墙上每隔一段就有一座敌楼[6]，士兵可以住在里面，也可以在里面放武器和粮食。在长城附近的山上，还有很多烽火台[7]。如果发现敌人，士兵就在烽火台上白天放烟，晚上点火，让远处[8]的人知道敌人来了。传说古人[9]会烧狼粪[10]，因为它的烟又黑又直，所以“狼烟[11]”后来成了战争的意思。

1 辛苦 *xīnkǔ* hard, toilsome
2 成千上万 *chéngqiān shàngwàn* thousands upon thousands
3 砖 *zhuān* brick
4 运 *yùn* to transport
5 犯人 *fànrén* convict
6 敌楼 *dílóu* watchtower
7 烽火台 *fēnghuǒtái* beacon tower
8 远处 *yuǎnchù* distant place
9 古人 *gǔrén* people of ancient times
10 狼粪 *lángfèn* wolf dung
11 狼烟 *lángyān* “wolf smoke”, beacon smoke

Building the wall was extremely hard work. Much of the wall stands on 8
mountains where paths were hard to walk, and heavy stones and countless bricks all had to be carried up by people and animals. It is said that in some places people stood in long lines and passed the bricks up the mountain one by one; others had goats carry bricks on their backs up the slopes. The builders were soldiers, but also farmers and convicts, and many of them never returned home.

The Great Wall is also more than just a wall. At intervals along the wall 9
stand watchtowers, where soldiers could live and where weapons and grain could be stored. On the hills near the wall there are also many beacon towers. If the enemy was spotted, the soldiers on the beacon towers sent up smoke by day and lit fires by night, so that people far away would know the enemy was coming. Legend has it that people in ancient times burned wolf dung, because its smoke was black and rose straight up; that is why "wolf smoke" later came to mean war.

9 明朝[1]的时候，人们还用烟和火的数量，再加上[2]放炮[3]的次数[4]，来表示敌人有多少。就这样，一个烽火台[5]接一个烽火台，消息很快就能传到几百公里以外。

10 长城上还有很多“关”，也就是有城门的地方，人和马车[6]可以从这里进出[7]。最有名的是东边的山海关[8]和西边的嘉峪关[9]。山海关靠近[10]大海，被叫做“天下第一关”[11]；嘉峪关在戈壁[12]上，四周[13]非常安静，常常让人想起古时候的边塞[14]生活。

1 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty
2 加上 *jiāshàng* plus, in addition
3 炮 *pào* cannon
4 次数 *cìshù* number of times
5 烽火台 *fēnghuǒtái* beacon tower
6 马车 *mǎchē* cart
7 进出 *jìnchū* to go in and out
8 山海关 *Shānhǎiguān* Shanhaiguan Pass
9 嘉峪关 *Jiāyùguān* Jiayuguan Pass
10 靠近 *kàojìn* near, close to
11 天下第一关 *Tiānxià Dìyī Guān* “the First Pass Under Heaven”
12 戈壁 *gēbì* the Gobi, stony desert
13 四周 *sìzhōu* all around
14 边塞 *biānsài* frontier fortress

In the Ming dynasty, the number of smokes or fires, together with the number of cannon shots, was used to show how many enemies there were. In this way, passing from one beacon tower to the next, news could travel hundreds of kilometres very quickly. 9

Along the wall there are also many "passes", places with gates where people and carts could go in and out. The most famous are Shanhaiguan in the east and Jiayuguan in the west. Shanhaiguan, close to the sea, is called "the First Pass Under Heaven"; Jiayuguan stands in the Gobi, and the deep silence all around it often makes visitors think of life on the frontier in ancient times. 10

从太空[1]能看到长城吗?

很多人都听过这样一种说法[2]：长城是人们在太空中唯一[3]能用眼睛看到的人造[4]建筑[5]，有人甚至说在月亮上也能看到。这种说法在很多书和课本里都出现过，可是它并不对。

长城虽然很长，但是并不宽，大部分地方只有几米宽。而且，长城的颜色和周围的山、土差不多，很难分出来。从几百公里高的太空往下看，用眼睛几乎不可能看到它；从月亮上看就更不可能了。有人打了一个比方[6]：从月亮上看长城，就像在五公里以外看一根头发。2003年，中国第一位航天员[7]杨利伟[8]坐“神舟五号[9]”飞上了太空。回来以后，记者问他有没有[10]看到长城，他回答说没有看到。

1 太空 *tàikōng* outer space
2 说法 *shuōfǎ* claim, version
3 唯一 *wéiyī* only, sole
4 人造 *rénzào* man-made
5 建筑 *jiànzhù* building, structure
6 比方 *bǐfang* comparison
7 航天员 *hángtiānyuán* astronaut
8 杨利伟 *Yáng Lìwěi* Yang Liwei, China's first astronaut
9 神舟五号 *Shénzhōu Wǔhào* Shenzhou 5 (spacecraft)
10 有没有 *yǒuméiyǒu* whether or not

Can You See the Great Wall from Space?

Many people have heard the claim that the Great Wall is the only man-made 11
structure that can be seen with the naked eye from space; some even say it can be seen from the moon. The claim has appeared in many books and textbooks, but it is not true.

Although the wall is very long, it is not wide: in most places it is only a 12
few metres across. What is more, its colour is much the same as the hills and earth around it, so it is hard to pick out. Looking down from space, several hundred kilometres up, it is almost impossible to see it with the naked eye; from the moon it is even less possible. Someone once put it this way: looking for the Great Wall from the moon is like trying to see a single hair from five kilometres away. In 2003, China's first astronaut, Yang Liwei, flew into space aboard Shenzhou 5. When he came back, reporters asked him whether he had seen the Great Wall, and he answered that he had not.

12 不过，用相机和长焦[1]镜头，在条件很好的时候，航天员[2]拍到过长城的照片。所以，长城的伟大不在于能不能从太空[3]看到，而在于它的历史和修建[4]它的人。

孟姜女[5]的故事

13 关于长城，最有名的民间故事是“孟姜女哭长城[6]”。传说在秦朝[7]的时候，有一个姑娘叫孟姜女。她刚刚和丈夫范喜良[8]结婚，丈夫就被官兵[9]抓走，送到北方去修长城了。孟姜女在家里等了很久，一直没有丈夫的消息。冬天快到了，她担心丈夫会冷，就亲手[10]做了冬天的衣服，一个人走了几千里路去找他。

1 长焦 *chángjiāo* telephoto
2 航天员 *hángtiānyuán* astronaut
3 太空 *tàikōng* outer space
4 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
5 孟姜女 *Mèng Jiāngnǚ* Meng Jiangnü, heroine of a folk tale
6 孟姜女哭长城 *Mèng Jiāngnǚ kū Chángchéng* “Meng Jiangnü Weeps at the Great Wall”
7 秦朝 *Qíncháo* the Qin dynasty
8 范喜良 *Fàn Xǐliáng* Fan Xiliang, her husband
9 官兵 *guānbīng* government soldiers
10 亲手 *qīnshǒu* with one’s own hands

However, using cameras with telephoto lenses and under very good conditions, astronauts have taken photographs of the wall. So the greatness of the wall does not lie in whether it can be seen from space, but in its history and in the people who built it. 12

The Story of Meng Jiangnü

The most famous folk tale about the wall is "Meng Jiangnü Weeps at the Great Wall". Legend says that in the Qin dynasty there lived a young woman called Meng Jiangnü. She had only just married her husband, Fan Xiliang, when he was seized by soldiers and sent north to work on the Great Wall. Meng Jiangnü waited at home for a long time, but never heard any news of him. As winter drew near, she worried that her husband would be cold, so she sewed winter clothes for him with her own hands and walked thousands of li alone to find him. 13

14 可是，等她终于走到长城下面的时候，别人告诉她，她的丈夫已经累死了，而且被埋[1]在了长城里。孟姜女[2]非常伤心，坐在长城下面大哭起来。她哭了三天三夜，突然“轰[3]”的一声[4]，一大段长城倒了下来，露出[5]了丈夫的尸骨[6]。这个故事当然不是真的历史，但是它说出了普通人的痛苦。今天，在山海关[7]附近还有一座孟姜女庙[8]，很多游客会去那里看一看。

今天的长城

15 中国人常说：“不到长城非好汉[9]”。意思是，没有去过长城，就不算真正的英雄[10]。所以，很多来北京的人一定要去爬长城。

1 埋 *mái* to bury
2 孟姜女 *Mèng Jiāngnǚ* Meng Jiangnü, heroine of a folk tale
3 轰 *hōng* boom!
4 声 *shēng* (measure word for sounds)
5 露出 *lùchū* to reveal
6 尸骨 *shīgǔ* remains, bones
7 山海关 *Shānhǎiguān* Shanhaiguan Pass
8 孟姜女庙 *Mèng Jiāngnǚ Miào* the Meng Jiangnü Temple
9 不到长城非好汉 *bù dào Chángchéng fēi hǎohàn* “no true hero until you reach the Great Wall”
10 英雄 *yīngxióng* hero

But when at last she reached the foot of the wall, she was told that her husband had worked himself to death and been buried inside the wall. Heartbroken, Meng Jiangnü sat down at the foot of the wall and began to weep. She wept for three days and three nights until suddenly, with a great roar, a long stretch of the wall came crashing down, revealing her husband's bones. This story is of course not real history, but it gives voice to the suffering of ordinary people. Today there is still a Meng Jiangnü Temple near Shanhaiguan, and many tourists go there to have a look. 14

The Great Wall Today

Chinese people like to say, "You are no true hero until you have reached the Great Wall." It means that if you have never been to the Great Wall, you cannot count as a real hero. So many people who come to Beijing make sure to go and climb the wall. 15

15 最有名的是八达岭[1]长城，它离北京市中心大约六七十公里，交通很方便，还可以坐高铁去。八达岭的长城修复[2]得很好，路比较好走，但是游客也特别多，节假日[3]的时候人多得几乎走不动。现在去八达岭需要提前在网上预约[4]，每天的游客人数也有限制。如果想人少一点，可以去慕田峪[5]，那里的风景也很美。

16 还有一些长城从来没有修复过，人们叫它们“野长城[6]”。野长城保留着几百年前的样子，墙上长满了草和小树，有的地方已经倒了。很多喜欢冒险[7]的人觉得野长城更有意思，也更漂亮。不过，爬野长城非常危险，每年都有人受伤，而且很多野长城是不允许[8]游客进去的。

1 八达岭 *Bādálǐng* Badaling, a section near Beijing
2 修复 *xiūfù* to restore
3 节假日 *jiéjiàrì* public holidays
4 预约 *yùyuē* to book in advance
5 慕田峪 *Mùtiányù* Mutianyu, a section near Beijing
6 野长城 *yě Chángchéng* the “wild wall”, unrestored sections
7 冒险 *màoxiǎn* to take risks
8 允许 *yǔnxǔ* to allow

The most famous section is Badaling, sixty or seventy kilometres from the centre of Beijing; it is easy to get to, and you can even go there by high-speed train. The wall at Badaling has been well restored and is fairly easy to walk on, but there are also enormous numbers of tourists; on public holidays it can be so crowded you can hardly move. Nowadays you need to book online in advance to visit Badaling, and the number of visitors each day is limited. If you would like fewer crowds, you can go to Mutianyu, where the scenery is beautiful too. 15

Some sections of the wall have never been restored; people call them the "wild wall". The wild wall still looks the way it did centuries ago: grass and small trees grow all over it, and in places it has already collapsed. Many people who like adventure find the wild wall more interesting, and more beautiful too. But climbing the wild wall is very dangerous, people get hurt every year, and many wild sections are closed to visitors. 16

17 因为风吹雨打[1]，再加上[2]人的破坏，很多长城正在慢慢消失。过去，有的农民把长城上的砖[3]拿回家盖房子；现在，也有游客在墙上写字、刻名字。1987年，长城成为了世界文化遗产。中国也制定了保护长城的法规[4]，修复[5]长城的时候，人们尽量用原来的材料和方法，做到“修旧如旧[6]”。

结语

18 长城不是一个人、一个朝代[7]修的，而是很多代人用两千多年的时间一点一点修起来的。它也许不能从太空[8]中看到，但是它的故事、它的历史，还有修建[9]它的无数普通人，都值得我们记住。下次你站在长城上的时候，可以摸一摸那些旧砖，想一想几百年前把它们搬上山的人。

1 风吹雨打 *fēngchuī yǔdǎ* battered by wind and rain
2 加上 *jiāshàng* plus, in addition
3 砖 *zhuān* brick
4 法规 *fǎguī* regulations
5 修复 *xiūfù* to restore
6 修旧如旧 *xiū jiù rú jiù* “repair the old so it stays old”
7 朝代 *cháodài* dynasty
8 太空 *tàikōng* outer space
9 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build

Battered by wind and rain, and damaged by people as well, many sections 17
of the wall are slowly disappearing. In the past, some farmers took bricks from the wall home to build their houses; today, some tourists write on the wall or carve their names into it. In 1987, the Great Wall became a World Cultural Heritage site. China has also drawn up regulations to protect the wall, and when it is repaired, people try to use the original materials and methods, so that "the old is repaired to look old".

In Closing

The Great Wall was not built by one person or one dynasty, but little by little 18
by many generations over more than two thousand years. It may not be visible from space, but its stories, its history and the countless ordinary people who built it are all worth remembering. Next time you stand on the Great Wall, touch the old bricks for a moment, and think of the people who carried them up the mountain hundreds of years ago.